



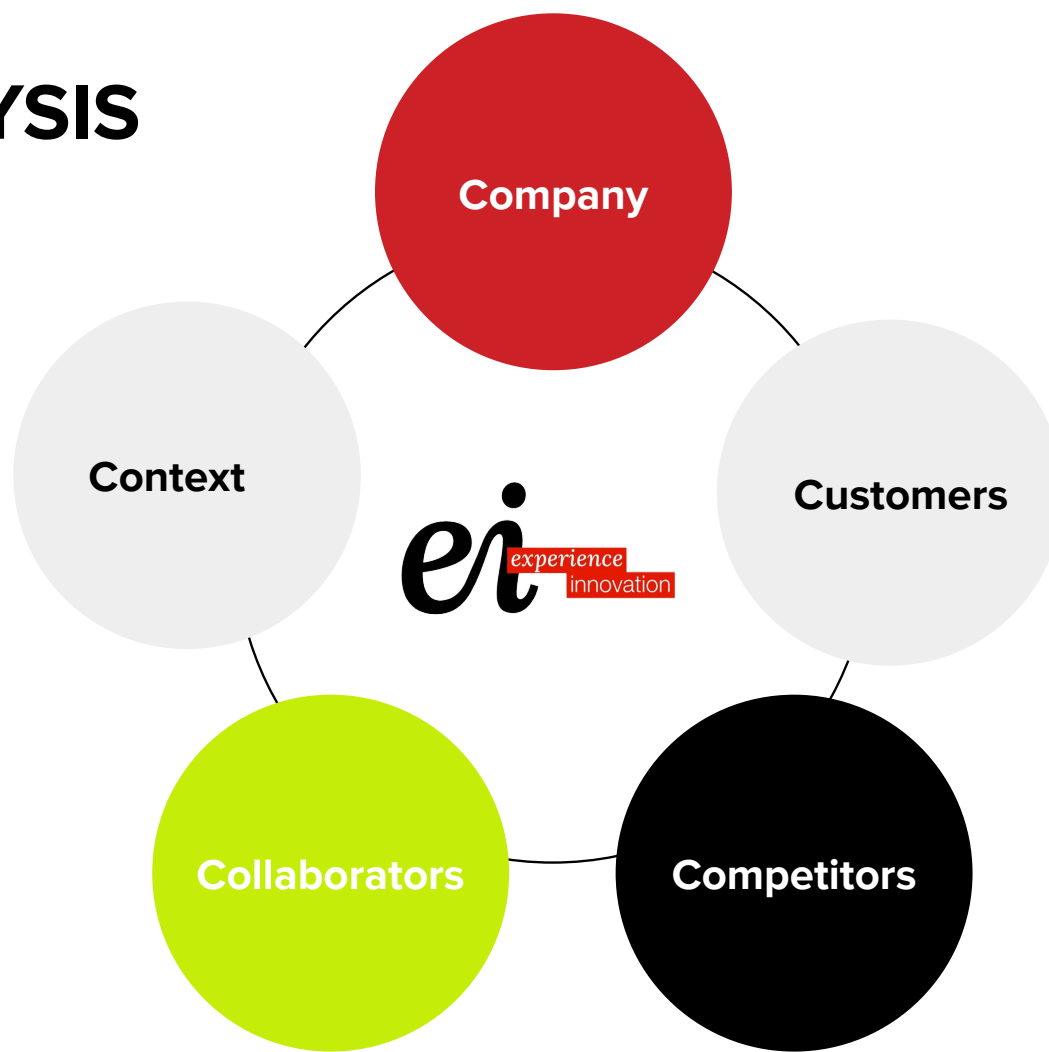
BRAND AUDIT

 School of Hospitality Administration

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09/22/2025



5Cs ANALYSIS



COMPANY – About BU SHA

Brand Overview

Boston University's School of Hospitality Administration (BU SHA) is a Boston-based academic institution offering undergraduate and graduate degrees in hospitality and service management. The school covers traditional sectors such as hotels, restaurants, and tourism, as well as emerging applications in healthcare, sports, entertainment, and retail. SHA combines industry-focused courses, field experiences, and international opportunities with a broad liberal arts education.

Mission

To prepare students to become innovative leaders in hospitality and service industries through rigorous academics, applied learning, and industry collaboration.

Vision

BU SHA is looking to cultivate a proud, close-knit community of hospitality professionals recognized for collaboration, innovation, and student-centered experiences.

Values

- Innovation and creativity
- Authentic student and staff storytelling
- Experiential learning and collaboration

COMPANY – Offerings & Positioning

Product/Service Overview

- Undergraduate degree programs offering majors such as Hospitality Administration and Hospitality & Communication.
- Graduate degree programs offering Master of Management and Master of Science.
- SHA also offers three graduate certificate programs: Events Management, Hospitality Management, Advanced Hospitality Management. Designed for working professionals, these certificates can be completed in as little as 3-4 months.
- Hands-on experiential learning through field experiences, applied research, and real-world hospitality challenges.
- Career support, industry engagement, and access to faculty and alumni networks.

Brand Positioning

- Boston University's SHA provides Boston's leading hospitality programs, combining rigorous academics with practical experience. Expressed by their motto "Experience Innovation", students are prepared to lead and create in hospitality fields.

Unique Selling Proposition (USP)

- BU SHA emphasizes experiential learning, requiring two 300-hour work experiences (internships or jobs in roles like front desk, events, or marketing) plus a global experience to give students first hand hospitality industry exposure.
- BU SHA highlights a strong network of industry connections, facilitated through the Marriott Career Center. This center provides students with resources that significantly contribute to the school's impressive career outcomes.

Notably, 98% of SHA graduates successfully launch their careers within three months of graduation.

COMPANY – Media Strategies

Platform	Followers	Strategy	Content Type	Interactions
Instagram 	2.6K	Posts student experiences, promotes events (spirit week, leadership summit, etc.), podcast clips	Photos, videos, infographics, story posts	Averages 20-70 likes, 0-10 comments (posts multiple times a week)
Facebook 	2.6K	Shares news, events/recaps, achievements	Photos, infographics	Low interactions, 1-5 likes per post recently
LinkedIn 	3.4K	Reposts BU posts, news, events/recaps, achievements	Identical feed to Facebook	Averaging 20-40 likes
Youtube 	408	Podcasts, events, news and updates	Videos	Podcast: 400-600 views Other posts: 30-100 views
TikTok 	146	Podcast clips, event recaps, student interviews	Videos	200-1000 views, averages 3-10 likes per post Has posted <40 videos between 2022-2025

CONSUMERS – Target Audience

Primary: Up-and-coming Hospitality Innovators

Demographic:

- Age: 18–22 (undergraduates exploring or enrolled in SHA), 21–28 (MMH/MS graduate students and early-career hospitality switchers)
- Gender/Ethnicity: Mixed and diverse; slightly female dominated common in hospitality programs
- Income: Middle to upper-middle; scholarship/assistantship sensitive, esp. for grad/international students
- Education stage: Current SHA undergraduates, MMH/MS graduate students and early-career professionals.

Geographic:

- Boston and the U.S. Northeast, with additional domestic interest from major metro areas and international interest from South/Southeast Asia, the Middle East, and China; many international students participate in study-abroad programs.

CONSUMERS – Target Audience

Mindset/values

- People-first, service-oriented, globally minded.
- Approach hospitality as designing meaningful, original experiences beyond conventional hotel roles.

Motivations

- Passionate about service and innovation.
- Driven to gain real-world skills, build networks, and connect with industry leaders.
- See hospitality as a way to turn personal interests (travel, food, events) into a career.

Lifestyle & Interests

- Urban, travel-curious, and food/events centric.
- Enjoy exploring new cultures, restaurants, nightlife, concerts, and sports.
- Active in student clubs, cultural orgs, or volunteering—naturally drawn to event planning and community-building.
- Comfortable navigating city life and public transit.

Frustrations

- Concerned about pay in hospitality careers.
- Face parental pressure toward “safer” business majors.
- International students often experience visa/OPT anxiety.

Media usage

- Instagram/TikTok → student life & program “vibe.”
- LinkedIn → internships, alumni, and seasonal job searching.
- YouTube → day-in-the-life videos, career panels.
- Reddit/Discord → peer advice, student discussions.

Purchase Behavior

- Pattern: Begin by researching programs online (websites, rankings, reviews), then join info sessions or campus visits. They talk to current students and alumni for an authentic view of culture and outcomes, and finally compare programs based on internships, global exposure, and scholarships.
- Drivers: Required industry hours, global placements, concentrations (rev mgmt/real estate/events), strong brand partners, placement data.
- Barriers: Cost vs. ROI, no direct first-year entry (undergrads), program fit vs. broader business degrees.
- Timing: Undergrads decide after 1–3 BU semesters; grad applications peak Nov–Mar with deposits by Spring.

COMPETITORS

Brand	Positioning	USP	Strength	Weakness	Social Engagement
	Experience-driven hospitality education in a major city; “experience innovation” across hotels, events, and service businesses.	Interdisciplinary undergrad and career-focused master’s, built around required experiential hours and direct connections to Boston’s hotels, restaurants, and event venues.	Boston location, hands-on learning, small and focused community.	Smaller national name compared to Cornell/UNLV, less ranking evidence, internal-transfer friction for undergrads.	Site and Instagram/LinkedIn highlights of internships, panels, and Boston Hospitality Review content.
	Ivy League, business-first hospitality with a global alumni network (“Hotelie” community).	Flagship MMH + deep real-estate/finance integration and AACSB business rigor.	Prestige/network, broad career paths, strong employer pipeline.	Costly and located in Ithaca, which limits direct access to major hospitality hubs. Its small, highly competitive program can also feel less accessible for some students from certain backgrounds.	High LinkedIn/alumni storytelling and steady research/events content.

COMPETITORS

Brand	Positioning	USP	Strength	Weakness	Social Engagement
	Industry-connected hospitality, travel & tourism programs leveraging NYC's ecosystem.	Big-city internships and marquee venue access; analytics/tech-aware grad offerings.	NYC location, variety of UG/MS options, frequent industry events.	Perceived as separate from core NYU, very high living costs, program identity that leans more toward tourism and events than traditional hotel operations.	Very active LinkedIn/Instagram; internship spotlights, alumni reels, conference clips.
	Practice-led hospitality in Las Vegas, the industry's backyard.	Top-rank visibility and strong value, embedded access to resorts, meetings, incentives, conferences, and exhibitions.	Ranking credibility, unmatched experiential access, value vs. private peers.	Reputation centered on casino and entertainment industries, public-funding variability, gaming/events association may narrow its hospitality appeal.	Frequent news on rankings/partnerships; energetic IG from on-strip venues and labs.

COLLABORATORS

Brand	Contribution	Strengths	Opportunities
	Essec Business School (France) allows graduate students to spend part of their MMH degree abroad under a formalized collaboration.	Adds global scale and prestige, gives students international exposure and networks.	Expand more exchange partnerships beyond this one (add other countries), better promote the international option to prospective students.
	Museum of Ice Cream (Boston) partnered with SHA's "Introduction to Customer Experience Management" course for a real-world project where students analyzed and improved customer experience.	Example of immersive, experiential learning, lets students apply concepts to real-world situations.	Repeat collaboration with new projects.
	The Marriott Career Center is a dedicated career hub for SHA students, offering career counseling, employer connections, internships, and recruiting events focused on hospitality.	Centralized, hospitality-focused career support.	Opportunity to expand employer partnerships and alumni networking events.
	Senior executives from Union Square Hospitality Group participated in SHA's Hospitality Leadership Summit, sharing industry insight.	Brings high-level hospitality expertise and networking opportunities to students.	Chance to establish formal internship or capstone projects between USHG and SHA.

CONTEXT – Market Trends

Program Design & Curriculum Trends

- According to a study of the top 15 QS-ranked hospitality & leisure management programs, universities are now emphasizing tailor-made specializations, high-quality brand internships, and hybrid curricula combining management, food & beverage, marketing, and digital skills. ([ResearchGate](#))
- In higher education, there's a push toward flexible credentials: micro-credentials, certificates, and skill-based assessment vs. purely credit-hour degrees are being implemented to address concerns about cost, speed, and job market alignment. ([Deloitte](#))

Industry and Career Readiness

- Experiential learning has been shown to outperform traditional lecture-based formats in student outcomes: hospitality educators and industry both see better readiness and mindset when internships, industrial placements, and lab/classroom hybrids are used. ([Taylor & Francis Online](#))
- Many programs now give students access to real hotel performance data and analytics tools, letting them practice forecasting and decision-making with the same resources used in the industry. ([STR](#))

Industry Trends & Market Outlook

- Recent reports highlight that personalization, sustainability, and tech adoption (AI, predictive maintenance, hyper-personalized guest experiences) are now the main industry trends and not optional add-ons. ([EHL Hospitality Insights 2025](#))
- Industry economic forecasts show the U.S. hospitality market reaching nearly US\$250 billion in 2025, with projected growth to ~US\$314 billion by 2030, indicating strong demand for workforce and innovation. ([Escoffier](#))

CONTEXT – Cultural Shifts

- **Contactless as baseline:** Mobile keys, digital check-in, kiosks, and cashless venues have moved from optional perks to standard expectations. Hotels that balance speed with a personal touch see the strongest guest satisfaction.
80% of hotel guests now expect some form of digital/automated check-in ([Agilysys](#)).
- **Experience over possessions:** Gen Z and Millennials value roles and brands that design memorable moments (festivals, luxury guest experiences, events) over purely transactional service.
78% of Gen Z say experiences matter more than material goods ([Eventbrite](#)).
- **AI goes operational:** Pricing, forecasting, guest messaging, and workflow automation are shifting from pilots to everyday practice. Schools are adding training in revenue analytics and AI-driven service tools.
60% of hospitality leaders report investing in AI-based service tools ([Deloitte](#)).
- **Creator-era recruiting:** Prospective students research schools via Instagram, TikTok, LinkedIn, and YouTube. Visible alumni career paths and internship proof matter as much as rankings.
- **Sustainability + wellness:** Demand for credible ESG action and well-being offerings is shaping brand loyalty. Hospitality programs that weave this into curriculum and projects stand out.
73% of travelers prefer brands with visible sustainability commitments ([Booking.com](#)).
- **Global/city culture:** Live events, food, and sports hospitality keep interest high in Boston, NYC, and Las Vegas—cities where culture fuels hospitality education and career pipelines.

CONTEXT – SWOT

Strengths

- Boston location with dense employer access (hotels, venues, sports/entertainment).
- Heavy experiential requirement and internships built into programs.
- Thought leadership via Boston Hospitality Review; small cohort size gives students direct access to faculty and peers.

Weaknesses

- Internal-transfer model for undergrads can add more steps and make the process complicated (SHA does not accept first year applicants.).
- SHA students rely on Boston's hospitality market for internships, which can be competitive and limited.

Opportunities

- Lead the AI + Revenue Management/Analytics lane (labs, badges, partner projects).
- Double down on city-based pipelines (Boston/NYC) and live-event partnerships.
- Package “experience guarantees” (micro-internships, client studios) to meet Gen-Z ROI expectations.
- Grow certificates (ESG, luxury service, event ops) for working pros and switchers.

Threats

- During economic slowdowns, travel demand will decrease, which can tighten internship and junior hiring.
- Intense competition from prestige brands and lower-cost public programs.
- National name recognition below Cornell/UNLV tier.
- Fewer public ranking proof points.
- Visa/OPT policy shifts could affect international yield.

5Cs SUMMARY / TAKEAWAY

Company

BU SHA offers industry-focused hospitality education combining rigorous academics with hands-on experiences and global exposure.

Consumers

Primarily undergrad and grad students seeking fast-tracked, people-first hospitality careers that turn passions for travel, food, and events into real-world skills, global opportunities, and strong industry connections.

Competitors

Other top hospitality programs like Cornell, NYU, and UNLV compete on the basis of prestige, network access, and opportunities.

Collaborators

Partners such as the Marriott Career Center, Union Square Hospitality Group executives, and international schools provide real-world projects, mentorship, and global exposure.

Context/Climate

Travel has bounced back but unevenly, U.S. hotel growth is cooling, Boston remains comparatively strong, AI is reshaping operations, and students prioritize ROI and hands-on experience.

STRATEGIC JUMPING-OFF POINTS

Human Insights

- People learn and connect best when they **actively experience** something, rather than just hearing about it. Seeing and doing makes an actual career feel more tangible.
 - The phrase “practice makes perfect” is something that has been instilled in us since childhood and it has been proven that students engage best through direct involvement. Getting this experience (constant improvement in a professional setting) builds confidence in a way that the traditional method of reading books and taking tests doesn’t.
- People are motivated by **belonging and personal development**. Growth feels more meaningful when shared with others and celebrated within a community.
 - Most students at university are away from home and would be drawn towards the comfort of having a community – a home away from home. Students would likely be more motivated to celebrate and share their achievements with like-minded peers. This, in turn, would improve performance and increase more community involvement.